CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

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RE: Fiji justice minister resigns · Five Eyes nears Arcadia AI pact · Wong accuses Greens leader of 'lining up with Putin' · Bougainville mine reopening revives civil war fears · Peters overrides ministers on UN pandemic vote

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,784	0.6975	13,750	0.5610
+0.55%	-0.10%	+0.36%	-0.25%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Documents · Upcoming · The Wire · Analysis

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Fiji Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka confirmed the resignation of Justice Minister Siromi Turaga days after an explicit video surfaced on his Facebook profile, the second such cabinet scandal since 2024.
2. New Zealand's Five Eyes partners are finalising arrangements for Arcadia, a shared military AI backbone, with NZDF expecting to sign a memorandum of understanding early next year.
3. Foreign Minister Penny Wong accused new Greens leader David Shoebridge of 'lining up with One Nation and President Putin' after he opposed Australian military aid to Ukraine, exposing a rift with Senator Sarah Hanson-Young.

TOP STORIES

NZ-DEFENSE

Five Eyes nears deal on shared military AI backbone

The New Zealand Defence Force says Five Eyes partners are finalising arrangements for Arcadia, a shared digital backbone that embeds AI across New Zealand, Australian, Canadian, British and American militaries. NZDF said Tuesday a memorandum of understanding is expected early next year, with partner militaries still reviewing staffing and a budget 'cost ceiling' yet to be approved. The Pentagon describes Arcadia as central to 'operationalising artificial intelligence and mastering command and control data flow.'

per RNZ: "Five Eyes nears deal on military AI project"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji justice minister resigns after explicit video scandal

Fiji Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** confirmed Tuesday he has accepted the resignation of Justice Minister **Siromi Turaga**, days after an explicit video appeared on Turaga's Facebook profile on the eve of Fiji's independence anniversary. Turaga, also acting Attorney-General, was in New Zealand when the clip surfaced; no replacement will be named immediately. It is the second such scandal in Rabuka's cabinet, after Information Minister **Lynda Tabuya**'s video leaked in 2024.

per RNZ Pacific: "Fiji's justice minister resigns following explicit video controversy"

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Wong accuses Greens leader of 'lining up with Putin' over Ukraine aid

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong** accused new Greens leader **David Shoebridge** of 'lining up with One Nation and President Putin' after he opposed Australian military aid to Ukraine. The remark exposed a rift inside the Greens, with Senator **Sarah Hanson-Young** breaking ranks to back continued assistance to Kyiv as parliament sparred over the scope of Australia's support.

per SMH (Matthew Knott): "Greens split over Ukraine military aid as Sarah Hanson-Young breaks ranks"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Panguna mine reopening push revives Bougainville civil war fears

Rising global copper demand has fueled interest in reopening Bougainville's Panguna mine, closed for four decades after fueling a civil war that killed thousands. The New York Times reports concern that a rush to restart the mine, seen as a potential funding source for a future Bougainville nation, risks a return to violence. The mine sits at the center of the autonomous Papua New Guinea region's path toward independence.

per NYT: "This Copper Mine Led to a Civil War. Can Reopening It Fund a New Nation?"

OVERNIGHT

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

New Zealand joins 30 nations condemning Iran attacks · RNZ

New Zealand joined 30 countries in a statement condemning Iran over alleged attacks, Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** said. The statement endorsed Britain's attribution of Iran to a suspected plot targeting RAF Fairford air base, which UK Prime Minister **Andy Burnham** called 'almost certainly' directed by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Five British men were arrested and later released on bail.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Jordan's King Abdullah II begins first Australia visit since 2016 · AP

King Abdullah II of Jordan began his first official visit to Australia since 2016, AP reported. The visit comes amid heightened Middle East tensions following recent attacks in Saudi Arabia and continued regional instability.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Britain urges Australia to join new J7 antisemitism plan · SMH World

Britain has offered to host a J7 group effort, drawing together countries with the largest Jewish populations outside Israel, to counter antisemitic hatred after incidents including the Bondi terror attack. Australia is among the nations being urged to back the initiative.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Lowy Institute: Australia's future hinges on US-China rivalry · Bloomberg

Bloomberg reports the Lowy Institute has found Australia's economic and strategic future depends on how Canberra manages the escalating rivalry between Washington and Beijing. The finding adds to a growing body of Australian strategic commentary on great-power competition.

US-AUSTRALIA

Albanese says Canberra will do 'whatever it can' on execution livestream · ABC News

Prime Minister **Anthony Albanese** said the government will do whatever it can to stop the livestream of a US firing-squad execution from being viewed in Australia, calling it 'abhorrent.' eSafety said it lacks power to proactively block the stream, placing responsibility on platforms. The execution of **Nidal Malik Hasan** is scheduled for December 3.

STAT OF THE DAY

3.1%

IMF 2027 inflation forecast for Australia

The forecast keeps price growth above the RBA's target band, adding pressure on the Albanese government as unemployment is also projected to rise.

AFR

PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · RNZ PACIFIC

Eight reported dead in PNG's Porgera mining violence

Local officials say up to eight people were killed in violence at Porgera Valley in PNG's Enga Province on September 23, with blame pointed at the Kumul 23 elite police unit. District administrator **Jerry Maku** said eight were confirmed dead; PNG Police deny Kumul 23 involvement, saying officers were responding to tribal conflict near the Porgera gold mine.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji remains on US trafficking watch list as convictions stall

Fiji failed for a second consecutive year to show progress against human trafficking and secured no convictions, Islands Business reports. The finding adds pressure on Suva as it pursues a major constitutional reform process.

TUVALU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Tuvalu presses for stronger disaster financing, insurance reform

Tuvalu Prime Minister **Feleti Teo** called for greater investment in regional disaster-financing institutions and changes to insurance triggers he said miss real losses. The appeal underscores Pacific states' push for climate and disaster finance that better matches on-the-ground damage.

VANUATU · ABC PACIFIC

Vanuatu PM flags concern over AFP numbers under Nakamal pact

Vanuatu Prime Minister **Jotham Napat** raised concerns after Australian Federal Police Assistant Commissioner **David McLean** told a Senate hearing the bilateral Nakamal Agreement allows an increase in AFP officers serving in Vanuatu. A spokesman for Napat said the two governments had not yet agreed to the change, which Vanuatu says reaffirms its existing laws.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

World Bank: Pacific energy security cannot wait for next fuel shock

A World Bank Group report, Toward a Secure, Affordable, and Resilient Energy Future, finds Pacific island electricity access and resilience planning must be built in now rather than after the next fuel price shock, Islands Business reports. The report frames energy security as inseparable from renewable investment across the region.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Pacific nations seek grants, relocation funds in loss-and-damage push

Pacific island countries are seeking funding for cash transfers, relocation and protection of cultural heritage and biodiversity in their loss-and-damage proposals, Islands Business reports. The demands signal continued Pacific pressure for climate finance structured as grants rather than loans.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · NEWSROOM NZ

Peters overrides ministers to block pandemic declaration vote

Foreign Minister **Winston Peters** overrode a majority of ministers who wanted New Zealand to vote in favour of a UN declaration on pandemic prevention, making a 'captain's call' since no Cabinet decision was required, Newsroom reports. The episode highlights Peters' latitude over foreign policy calls within the National-led coalition.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · REUTERS

China's premier offers to expand NZ cooperation on EVs, clean power

China's premier said Beijing is ready to expand cooperation with New Zealand on new-energy vehicles and clean power, Reuters reports. The overture comes as Wellington balances economic ties with Beijing against security commitments to Five Eyes partners ahead of the November 7 election.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

FIJI · OTHER · ABC POLITICS

Fiji presses US for evidence against Chinese businessman

The Fijian government has asked the United States to provide evidence supporting corruption allegations against a prominent Chinese-Fijian businessman, ABC reports. The request follows US claims that have drawn scrutiny of the businessman's dealings in Fiji.

FIJI · OTHER · FBC NEWS (FIJI) STATE MEDIA

China denies US allegations of state-backed cyberattacks

The Chinese Embassy in Fiji rejected US allegations of Chinese state-supported cyberattacks, saying accusations against other countries must be backed by evidence. The embassy said China opposes hacking activities and accused Washington of politicising cybersecurity.

FIJI · SENIOR VISIT · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Taiwan's Fiji envoy says security investment underpins Pacific peace

Taiwan's Trade Representative to Fiji, **David Wu**, said Taiwan must invest in security to live in peace, strengthening its case for a continued Pacific role. The comments come as Taiwan is reported to be attending the 2026 Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting after exclusion from the 2025 gathering in Solomon Islands.

REGIONAL · SENIOR VISIT · PACIFIC ISLAND TIMES

US, three North Pacific states sign letter on new Peace Corps program

On the sidelines of the Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in Koror, presidents **Wesley Simina** of the Federated States of Micronesia, **Surangel Whipps Jr.** of Palau and **Hilda Heine** of the Marshall Islands joined US Deputy Secretary of State **Christopher Landau** to sign a letter of intent establishing a North Pacific Peace Corps program, Pacific Island Times reports.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Labor MPs push to save ATO credit card payments after surcharge ban

Frustrated Labor MPs are pressing the federal government for a permanent fix after a surcharge ban led the Tax Office to stop accepting credit cards, SMH reports. The dispute dominated Tuesday's political brawl in Canberra, with MPs fearing a prolonged campaign from business groups and the opposition.

AU-POLITICS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Small business minister reports 19 death threats amid ATO row

Liberal **Angie Bell** said she received *19 death threats* this week after the ATO credit card dispute escalated, and was rebuked for saying **Anthony Albanese** and **Anne Aly** should be 'stoned in the square.' The remark drew cross-party criticism as the credit card surcharge fight intensified.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Pocock raises concern over PMO's edits to draft AI inquiry advice

Senator **David Pocock** said the Prime Minister's office had marked up a draft letter from co-chairs of a bipartisan AI inquiry to Anthony Albanese, ABC reports. Labor and the Coalition rejected claims of undue interference; the committee's recommendations include independent safety checks on AI firms and a copyright review, due in a final report in November.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Chalmers warns Labor can't assume One Nation support will fade

Treasurer **Jim Chalmers** told the Australia Institute that One Nation's political momentum is unlikely to disappear quickly and urged colleagues not to 'mock' or 'talk down' to its supporters. Anthony Albanese said he was not 'spooked' by the party's polling strength as cost-of-living pressure and this year's rate rises weigh on voters.

AU-POLITICS · ABC POLITICS

Liberal response to Josh Frydenberg's possible return stays lukewarm

ABC reports a lukewarm reception within the Liberal Party to speculation that **Josh Frydenberg** could return to politics, despite leader **Angus Taylor** saying he would welcome it. The muted response underscores lingering divisions inside the Coalition over its post-leadership-spill direction.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Air New Zealand seeks Virgin Australia pact to counter Qantas

Air New Zealand is seeking a partnership with Virgin Australia to compete more effectively against Qantas, Bloomberg reports. The move reflects intensifying trans-Tasman aviation competition as both carriers reassess alliances.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

IMF: Australia's inflation among the worst, unemployment rising

The IMF forecasts Australian inflation will remain above the Reserve Bank's target band next year at *3.1 percent*, AFR reports, while unemployment is also projected to climb. The findings add pressure on the Albanese government as it manages a weakening labour market alongside above-target prices.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

RBA board minutes: weaker growth must be accepted to beat inflation

Minutes from the Reserve Bank's board meeting say weaker economic growth must be tolerated to bring inflation back to target, AFR reports, and flagged that further price rises and corresponding rate increases remain possible. The central bank held its cash rate at 4.35 percent for a second consecutive meeting in August.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Coalition presses ASIC to examine collapsed Firmus float

The Australian reports the Coalition is pressing corporate regulator ASIC to examine the collapsed Firmus initial public offering, amid criticism of the deal's market integrity. The float's failure has already drawn scrutiny of its backers and valuation.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

JOINT STATEMENT · AU MINISTERIAL

Australia joins joint statement on support for the International Criminal Court

Foreign Minister Penny Wong's office issued a joint statement reaffirming Australian support for the International Criminal Court. No further detail on co-signatories or specific content was available in the release.

UPCOMING

OCT 26 — **New Zealand advance voting opens**
Marks the start of voting in the fragmented MMP race ahead of the November 7 election.

NOV 7 — **New Zealand general election**
Determines whether the National-ACT-NZ First coalition continues or a new government forms.

DEC 3 — **Scheduled US execution of Nidal Malik Hasan**
Canberra is weighing options to block a livestream of the execution from reaching Australian platforms.

DEC 2026 — **Fiji constitutional reform referendum**
A referendum would test Prime Minister Rabuka's reform agenda amid a fresh cabinet scandal.

THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Devpolicy: PNG students reflect on leadership, corruption at 50 years

A Devpolicy Blog analysis of PNG university students marking 50 years of independence finds candid views on leadership, corruption and inequality, and the values needed to shape the nation's future. The research was conducted through the ANU-UPNG Partnership, funded by Australia's Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

LOWY INTERPRETER

Lowy Interpreter: security scrutiny reshapes Australia-China research ties

The Lowy Interpreter reports that while Australia-China research ties remain strong, heightened security scrutiny now demands case-by-case assessment of the risks and benefits of academic collaboration. The piece argues blanket restrictions risk undermining legitimate research partnerships.

ASPI STRATEGIST

ASPI Strategist: Australia should pursue nuclear diplomacy with India bilaterally

An ASPI Strategist piece argues Australia should complement its multilateral non-proliferation work, centred on the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, with bilateral nuclear diplomacy, particularly with India. The author says the time is right for Canberra to broaden its approach beyond global treaty frameworks.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

NOT SPECIFIED IN SOURCE · THE DIPLOMAT

Wolf Warriors in Sheep's Clothing: China's New Subnational Diplomacy in Australia

The Diplomat examines how Chinese consular officials are using the rhetoric of 'cooperation' and 'mutual benefit' favoured by Canberra to pursue subnational diplomacy with Australian states, cities and communities, a softer complement to earlier wolf warrior postures.

Argument: Beijing's diplomatic officials are adopting the Albanese government's own language to press demands on Australian local governments and communities.

NOT SPECIFIED IN SOURCE · THE DIPLOMAT

Australia's Billionaire Problem and the 'Corruption of the Democratic Process'

The piece argues incoming Australian political donation caps and spending limits, while historic, are structured loosely enough to leave major-party fundraising largely intact, with full effect delayed until after the next election cycle.

Argument: Australia's new political finance laws cap donations and spending for the first time but set generous limits, complex rules and a convenient two-year delay for major parties.

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